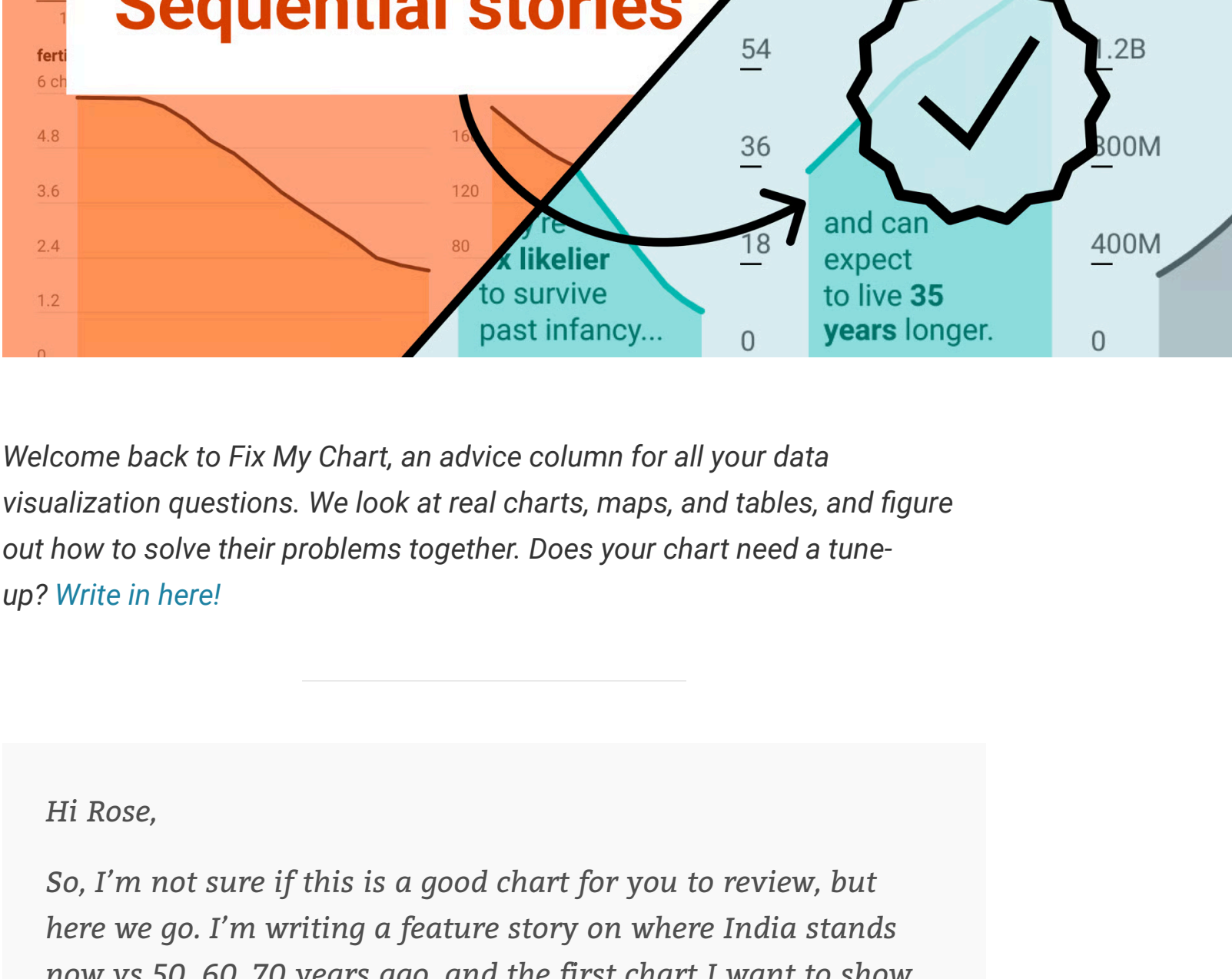


Fix my chart
4 min
September 30th, 2024

Fix my chart » Sequential storytelling

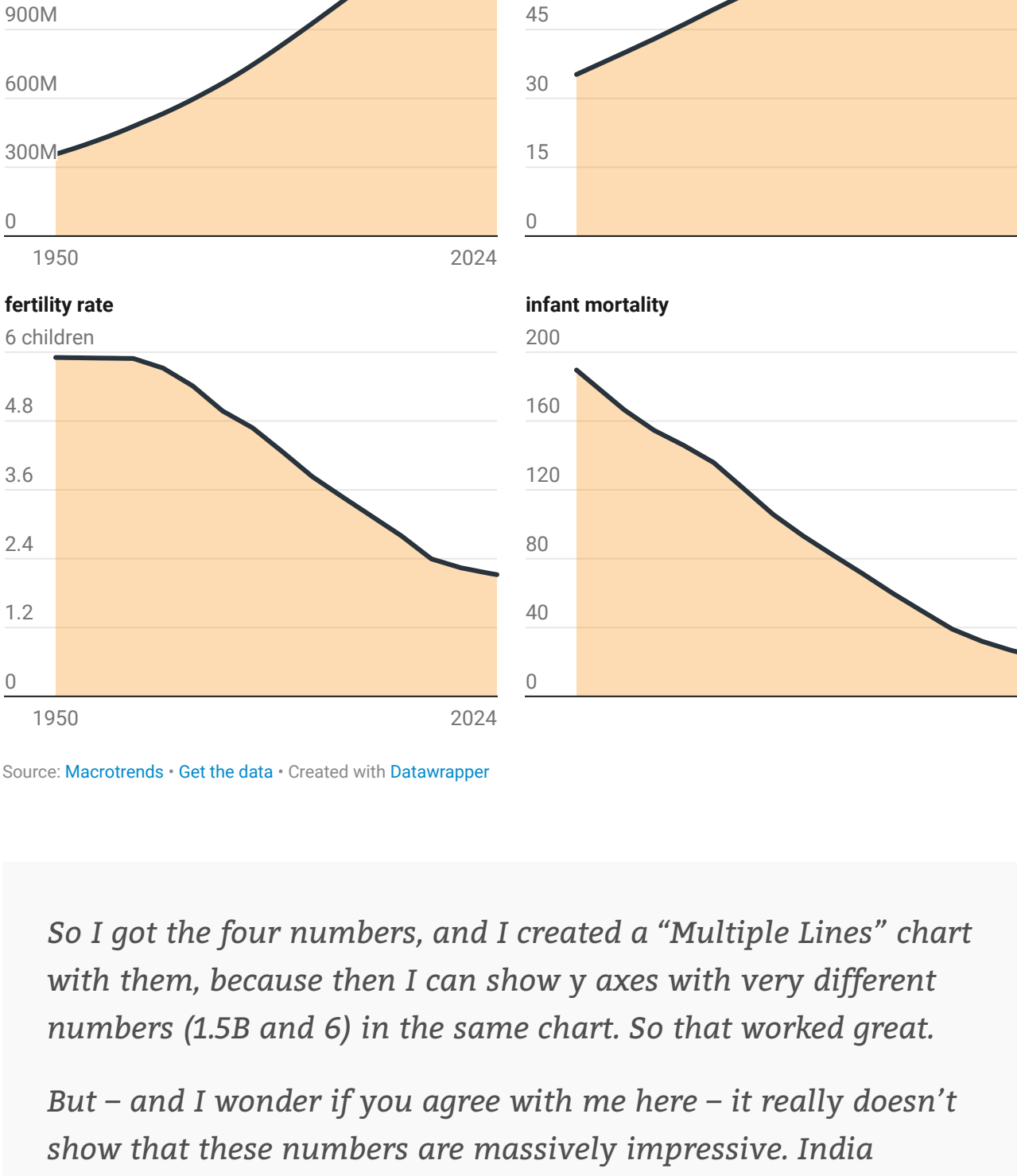
Welcome back to Fix My Chart, an advice column for all your data visualization questions....



Welcome back to Fix My Chart, an advice column for all your data visualization questions. We look at real charts, maps, and tables, and figure out how to solve their problems together. Does your chart need a tune-up? [Write in here!](#)

India has seen a massive change in their demographic numbers over the last 75 years

Four key indicators between 1950 and 2024



So I got the four numbers, and I created a “Multiple Lines” chart with them, because then I can show y axes with very different numbers (1.5B and 6) in the same chart. So that worked great.

But – and I wonder if you agree with me here – it really doesn’t show that these numbers are massively impressive. India quadrupled its population and doubled life expectancy within 75 years, which is bonkers.

But the chart doesn’t give me bonkersness vibes. It shows “two numbers up, two done” but I don’t think it says “This is crazy!” and I’m not sure it shows the how the numbers are connected. I tried to get a bit closer to that with the title, but I wonder what you think, is that enough?

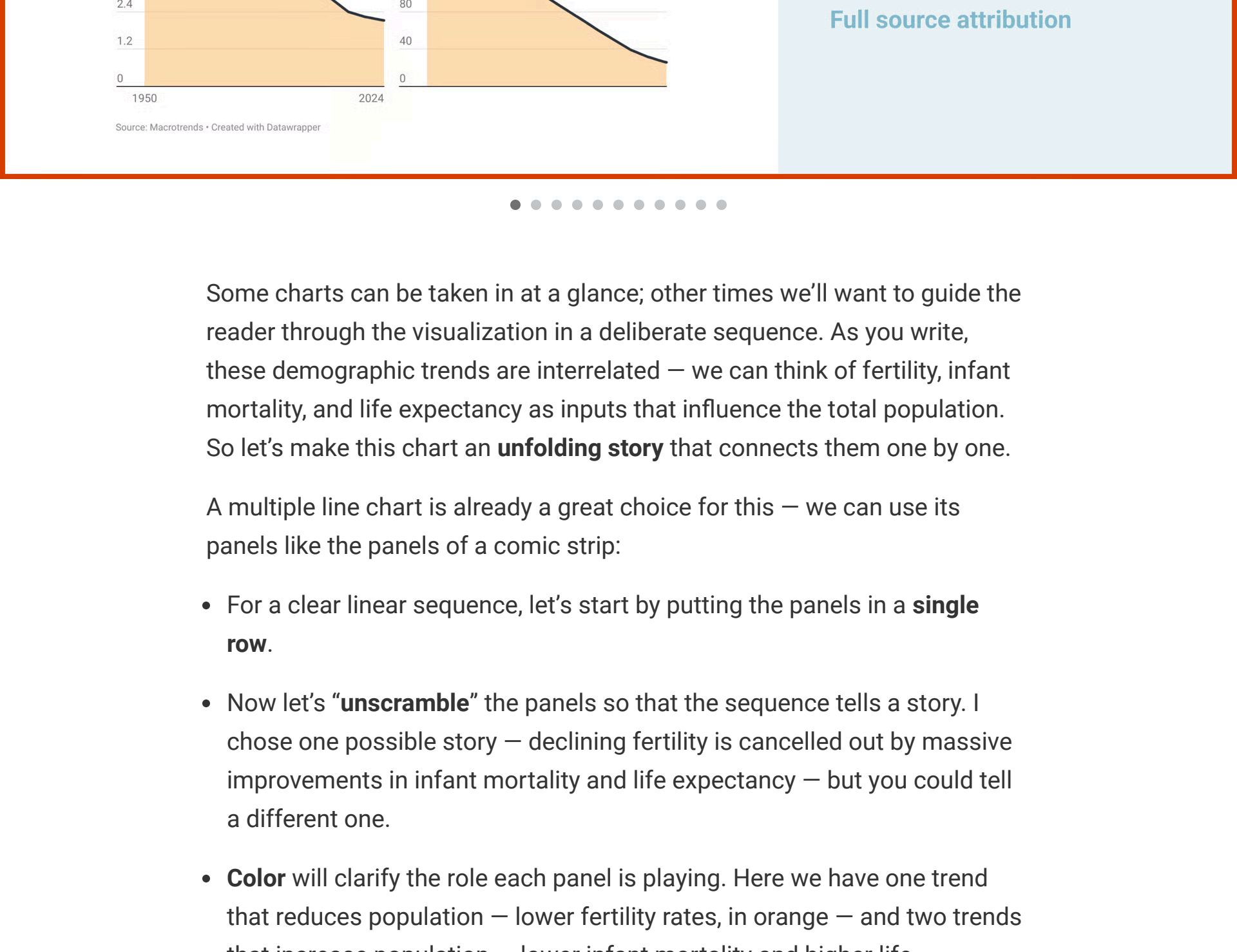
How can I make people be appropriately amazed by numbers in such a simple chart?

Thanks for having a look!

Katie

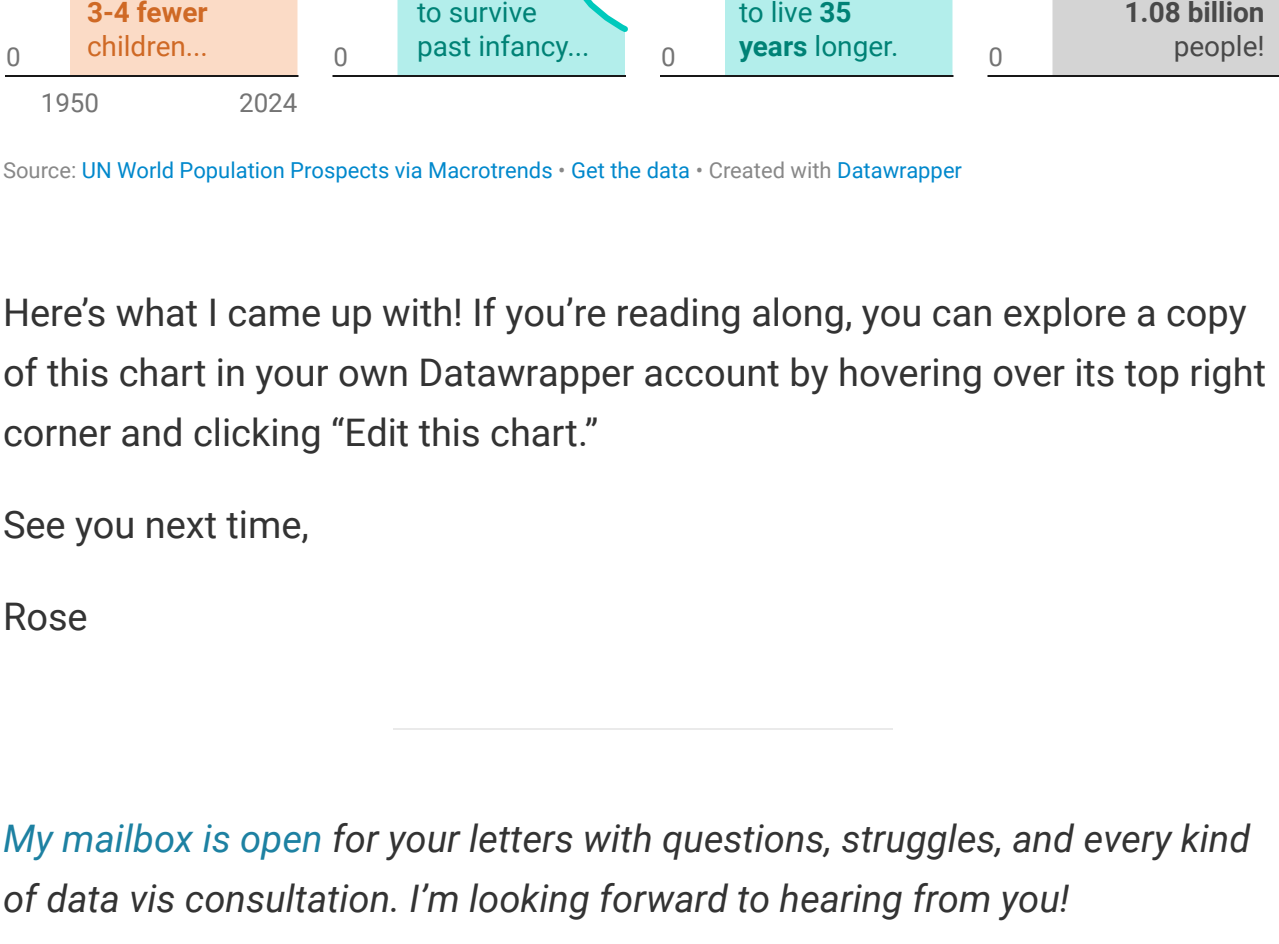
Dear Katie,

I absolutely love the idea of working to increase a chart’s “bonkersness vibes.” There’s an incredible social transformation behind these lines and you’re right, we can show it! What’s more, I think you’ve already identified the way to do so – by showing how all four trends are related.



- For a clear linear sequence, let’s start by putting the panels in a **single row**.
- Now let’s “**unscramble**” the panels so that the sequence tells a story. I chose one possible story – declining fertility is cancelled out by massive improvements in infant mortality and life expectancy – but you could tell a different one.
- Color** will clarify the role each panel is playing. Here we have one trend that reduces population – lower fertility rates, in orange – and two trends that increase population – lower infant mortality and higher life expectancy, in green.
- Now we’ll write our strip! **Text annotations** fill in your narrative.

Demographic changes have transformed India in just 75 years



Here’s what I came up with! If you’re reading along, you can explore a copy of this chart in your own Datawrapper account by hovering over its top right corner and clicking “Edit this chart.”

See you next time,

Rose

My mailbox is open for your letters with questions, struggles, and every kind of data vis consultation. I’m looking forward to hearing from you!

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